UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

Invitational A • 2011



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • Invitational A • 2011

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The common English verse triple-syllable foot consisting of one accented syllable followed by two unaccented syllables is the

   A) anapest.
   B) antibacchius.
   C) dactyl.
   D) iamb.
   E) pyrrhic.

2. The Germanic dialect that was spoken in the British Isles between the invasion of the Anglo-Saxons during the fifth century and the Norman Conquest in the eleventh century is

   A) Danish.
   B) Frisian.
   C) Norse.
   D) Old English.
   E) Romany.

3. Not characterized by sadness or lamentation is the

   A) dirge.
   B) elegy.
   C) monody.
   D) quibble.
   E) threnody.

4. The body of doctrine thought to be derived from or to reflect the qualities of ancient Greek and Roman culture, particularly in literature, philosophy, and art, is

   A) classicism.
   B) Hebraism.
   C) Hellenism.
   D) humanism.
   E) primitivism.

5. The British author of the five-volume *Bildungsroman* entitled *Children of Violence* who was awarded the 2007 Nobel Prize for Literature is

   A) Doris Lessing.
   B) V. S. Naipaul.
   C) Harold Pinter.
   D) Bertrand A. W. Russell.
   E) George Bernard Shaw.

6. The Michiganian who won the 1954 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry for his collection entitled *The Waking* is

   A) John Berryman.
   B) Donald Justice.
   C) Theodore Roethke.
   D) Mark Strand.
   E) Franz Wright.

7. The term applied to the work of a group of contemporary poets whose poetry features a public and sometimes painful display of private, personal matters is

   A) confessional poetry.
   B) didactic poetry.
   C) patter song.
   D) popular literature.
   E) sapphic verse.

8. Words with the same or similar meanings are

   A) antonyms.
   B) eponyms.
   C) heteronyms.
   D) homonyms.
   E) synonyms.

9. The term that, from the very late nineteenth century through the twenty-first, denotes the various newspapers and magazines specializing in scandal and sensation is

   A) affective fallacy.
   B) intentional fallacy.
   C) metafiction.
   D) pathetic fallacy.
   E) yellow journalism.

10. The term applied to the "first" actor, the leader of the chorus, in early Greek drama and that now refers to the central character is

    A) antagonist.
    B) anti-hero.
    C) deuteragonist.
    D) protagonist.
    E) tritagonist.

11. The poetic foot consisting of an accented and an unaccented syllable, as in the word *happy*, is the

A) anapest.
B) dactyl.
C) pyrrhic.
D) spondee.
E) trochee.

12. The dramatist who received Pulitzers in 1948 and 1955 for *A Streetcar Named Desire* and *Cat on a Hot Tin Roof*, respectively, is

A) Archibald MacLeish.
B) David Mamet.
C) Eugene O'Neill.
D) Howard Sackler.
E) Tennessee Williams.

13. An inappropriateness of speech resulting from the use of one word for another that resembles it is known as a(n)

A) Erastianism.
B) Euphemism.
C) Grundyism.
D) Malapropism.
E) Spoonerism.

14. The group of American writers, including Ida Tarbell, Lincoln Steffens, and Upton Sinclair, who between 1902 and 1911 worked to expose the dishonest methods and unscrupulous motives in big business and in city, state, and national government is

A) the Agrarians.
B) The Fugitives.
C) the Hartford Wits.
D) the Lost Generation.
E) the Muckrakers.

15. Not among the poets who contributed to the nineteenth century's Romantic movement in England is

A) Samuel Taylor Coleridge.
B) Alexander Pope.
C) Percy Bysshe Shelley.
D) Robert Southey.
E) William Wordsworth.

16. The revival of emotional religion during the first half of the eighteenth century in America is

A) the Great Awakening.
B) Dandyism.
C) the Harlem Renaissance.
D) Philistinism.
E) Transcendentalism.

17. A poetic line consisting of six feet, the conventional medium for Greek and Roman epic and didactic poetry, is the

A) heptameter.
B) hexameter.
C) octameter.
D) pentameter.
E) tetrameter.

18. This year is the fiftieth anniversary of Harper Lee's being awarded the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for her novel

A) *Gone with the Wind*.
B) *The Great Gatsby*.
C) *The Sun Also Rises*.
D) *To Kill a Mockingbird*.
E) *Where the Red Fern Grows*.

19. The genre of novel dominated by social customs, conventions, and habits of a particular social class, including the novels of Jane Austen, which is always characterized by realism and at times by satire, is the

A) novel of character.
B) novel of incident.
C) novel of manners.
D) novel of sensibility.
E) novel of the soil.

20. The rule-governed arrangement of words in sentences is

A) inversion.
B) semantics.
C) semiotics.
D) structuralism.
E) syntax.

21. The literary movement immediately associated with the Abbey Theatre and William Butler Yeats is

A) the Harlem Renaissance.
B) the Irish Literary Revival.
C) Johnson's Circle.
D) the Pre-Raphaelites.
E) Scholasticism.

22. A chronicle, usually autobiographical, presenting the life story of a rascal of low degree engaged in menial tasks and making his living more through his wit than his industry, and tending to be episodic and structureless, is known as a(n)

A) epistolary novel.
B) novel of character.
C) novel of manners.
D) novel of the soil.
E) picaresque novel.

23. The author whose *Collected Letters* was published in November 2010 and whose *Humboldt's Gift* won him the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction in 1976 is

A) Saul Bellow.
B) Cormac McCarthy.
C) N. Scott Momaday.
D) Philip Roth.
E) John Updike.

24. The device by which a work presents material that occurred prior to the opening scene of a work is

A) digression.
B) elaboration.
C) flashback.
D) foreshadowing.
E) prolepsis.

25. The type of lyric poem that is characterized by its single, unified strain of exalted feeling and style, by its single purpose, and by its dealing with one theme is the

A) aubade.
B) elegy.
C) hymn.
D) ode.
E) sonnet.

26. The diagram that is often used to reflect the structure of a five-act tragedy is known as

A) episodic structure.
B) Freytag's pyramid.
C) hermeneutic circle.
D) lipogram.
E) quintain.

27. The nineteenth-century American author of *Twice-Told Tales*, *The House of the Seven Gables*, *The Marble Faun*, *The Celestial Railroad and Other Short Stories*, *The Blithedale Romance, and Mosses from an Old Manse*, is

A) James Fenimore Cooper.
B) Ralph Waldo Emerson.
C) Nathaniel Hawthorne.
D) Herman Melville.
E) Henry David Thoreau.

28. An analogy identifying one object with another and ascribing to the first object one or more of the qualities of the second is called (a)

A) conceit.
B) metaphor.
C) metonymy.
D) simile.
E) synecdoche.

29. Not among the remarkable writers of sonnets during England's Elizabethan Age is

A) John Keats.
B) William Shakespeare.
C) Philip Sidney.
D) Edmund Spenser.
E) the Earl of Surrey.

30. The period in English Literature spanning the years 1660-1798 and including the Restoration Age, the Augustan Age, and the Age of Johnson is known as the

A) Contemporary Period.
B) Modernist Period.
C) Neoclassic Period.
D) Realistic Period.
E) Romantic Period.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with Eugene O'Neill's *The Hairy Ape*.
Items 37-43 are associated with Jane Austen's *Pride and Prejudice*.
Items 44-50 are associated with Theodore Roethke's poetry (selected).

31. The observation "Six days in hell" made by the Voices in O'Neill's *The Hairy Ape* refers to the
    A) duration of the transatlantic journey.
    B) duration of Yank's relationship with Mildred.
    C) length of time the crew spends in Southampton.
    D) length of time Yank spends in the gorilla's cage.
    E) length of time Yank spent in jail.

32. "Please do not mock at my attempts to discover how the other half lives" is a protest by
    A) Mildred to her aunt.
    B) Mildred to her father.
    C) Paddy to Yank.
    D) Yank to Paddy.
    E) Yank to the gorilla.

33. Yank, in explaining to Long why he was unable to get even with Mildred near "de gangplank" in Southampton, says, "Dere was a whole army of plainclothes bulls around. Dey spotted me and gimme de bum's rush"; his reference is to
    A) aristocrats.
    B) engineers.
    C) policemen.
    D) stokers.
    E) Wobblies.

34. Yank is actually called a hairy ape by
    A) Mildred.
    B) Mildred's aunt.
    C) no one.
    D) Paddy.
    E) Robert Smith.

35. The I.W.W., an organization that is either referenced or serves as an integral factor in many of O'Neill's writings, including *The Iceman Cometh* and *The Hairy Ape*, is the
    A) Industrial Workers of the World.
    B) Institute for Women and Work.
    C) International Workers of the World.
    D) Internet Writing Workshop.
    E) Iowa Writers' Workshop.

36. The protagonist of Eugene O'Neill's *The Hairy Ape* is
    A) the I.W.W.
    B) Long.
    C) Mildred Douglas.
    D) Paddy.
    E) Robert Smith.

37. The property at the center of the entailment controversy in Austen's *Pride and Prejudice* is
    A) Gretna Green.
    B) Longbourn.
    C) Lucas Lodge.
    D) Pemberley.
    E) Netherfield.

38. The declaration, "I am not afraid; for though I *am* the youngest, I'm the tallest," is a response to Mrs. Bennet's having stated, "I dare say Mr. Bingley will dance with you at the next ball" and is spoken by
    A) Elizabeth.
    B) Jane.
    C) Kitty.
    D) Lydia.
    E) Mary.

39. A hack chaise, a phaeton, and a gig are types of
    A) card games.
    B) carriages.
    C) dances.
    D) gardens.
    E) regimental ribbons.

40. In his letter to Mr. Bennet, the news that he had "been so fortunate as to be distinguished by the patronage of the Right Honorable Lady Catherine de Bourgh," is offered by
    A) Charles Bingley.
    B) Lewis de Bourgh.
    C) William Collins.
    D) Edward Gardiner.
    E) William Lucas.

41. The powerful observation informing the question "[W]hat is the difference in matrimonial affairs, between the mercenary and the prudent? Where does discretion end, and avarice begin?" is posed by

A) Elizabeth Bennet.
B) Kitty Bennet.
C) Anne de Bourgh.
D) Catherine de Bourgh.
E) Charlotte Lucas.

42. The young couple whose "easy assurance" upon returning from Brighton and London was "enough to provoke" Mr. Bennet, "disgust" Elizabeth, and even "shock" Mrs. Bennet is

A) Caroline and Charles.
B) Georgiana and George.
C) Jane and Charles.
D) Lizzy and Fitzwilliam.
E) Lydia and George.

43. "Far be it for me, my dear sister, to deprecate such pleasure [a visit to the George]. They doubtless be congenial with generality of female minds. But I confess they would have no charms for *me*. I should infinitely prefer a book," declares

A) Caroline to Georgiana.
B) Charlotte to Lizzy.
C) Elizabeth to Jane.
D) Lydia to Mary.
E) Mary to Lydia.

Items 44-46 refer to Theodore Roethke's

Cuttings *later*

This urge, wrestle, resurrection of dry sticks,
Cut stems struggling to put down feet,
What saint strained so much,
Rose on such lopped limbs to a new life?

I can hear, underground, that sucking and sobbing,
In my veins, in my bones I feel it, —
The small waters seeping upward,
The tight grains parting at last.

When sprouts break out,
Slippery as fish,
I quail, lean to beginnings, sheath-wet.

44. The simile that informs the final stanza of Roethke's "Cuttings *later*" is anchored in

A) auditory imagery.
B) gustatory imagery.
C) olfactory imagery.
D) tactile imagery.
E) visual imagery.

45. The tone of the poem, especially as it surfaces in the lines "What saint strained so much, / Rose on such lopped limbs to new life," is

A) elegiac.
B) facetious.
C) melancholy.
D) sympathetic.
E) wistful.

46. Thematically, Roethke's "Cuttings *later*" addresses, through the botanical imagery that equates the organic world around him with his own self, the "urge" and struggle that he associates with

A) arranging cut flowers without a vase.
B) birthing of inner creativity.
C) discovering that quail are in his garden.
D) finding a rose blooming on a cut stem.
E) "sucking and sobbing" waters underground.

Items 47-48 refer to Theodore Roethke's

The Bat

By day the bat is cousin to the mouse.
He likes the attic of an aging house.

His fingers make a hat about his head.
His pulse beat is so slow we think him dead.

He loops in crazy figures half the night
Among the trees that face the corner light.

But when he brushes up against a screen,
We are afraid of what our eyes have seen:

For something is amiss or out of place
When mice with wings can wear a human face.

47. The form of the third and fifth stanzas of Roethke's "The Bat" is the

A) blank verse.
B) closed couplet.
C) free verse.
D) heroic couplet.
E) short couplet.

48. The kinship that is intimated in the last two stanzas of "The Bat" carries with it a sense of

A) deep respect.
B) fiendish dispassion.
C) ghoulish death.
D) momentary shock.
E) pleasant surprise.

Items 49-50 refer to Theodore Roethke's

On the Road to Woodlawn

I miss the polished brass, the powerful black horses,
The drivers creaking the seats of the baroque hearses,
The high-piled floral offerings with sentimental verses,
The carriages reeking with varnish and stale perfume.

I miss the pallbearers momentously taking their places,
The undertaker's obsequious grimaces,
The craned necks, the mourners' anonymous faces,
—And the eyes, still vivid, looking up from a sunken room.

49. The inherent contrast between the funeral processions conjured up in the persona's recollection and what must have replaced them constitutes a variant of the literary convention known as

A) *carpe diem*.
B) leitmotif.
C) *memento mori*.
D) *ubi sunt*.
E) *vade mecum*.

50. The type of rhyme that characterizes the first three lines of each of the stanzas of "On the Road to Woodlawn" is

A) compound rhyme.
B) feminine rhyme.
C) leonine rhyme.
D) masculine rhyme.
E) triple rhyme.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-53 refer to Robert Frost's

Neither Out Far nor In Deep

The people along the sand
All turn and look one way.
They turn their back on the land.
They look at the sea all day.

As long as it takes to pass
A ship keeps raising its hull;
The wetter ground like glass
Reflects a standing gull.

The land may vary more;
But wherever the truth may be—
The water comes ashore,
And the people look at the sea.

They cannot look out far.
They cannot look in deep.
But when was that ever a bar
To any watch they keep?

51. The theme of Robert Frost's "Neither Out Far nor In Deep" addresses

A) beauty in the eyes of the observant.
B) human limitations.
C) people's longing for the sea.
D) people's propensity to stare at moving things.
E) tidal influence on people's souls.

52. The inward and outward perspectives offered in the poem's imagery are best seen in lines

A) 2 and 4.
B) 3 and 12.
C) 4 and 7.
D) 6 and 7.
E) 7 and 9.

53. The poem's tone, which is ultimately defined by the commentary of its final stanza, might be understood to be

A) cautiously, if not tragically, optimistic.
B) despairingly scornful.
C) forcefully and persuasively expectant.
D) mockingly disdainful.
E) ironically, if not whimsically, facetious.

Items 54-57 refer to John Keats's

To Sleep

O soft embalmer of the still midnight,
Shutting, with careful fingers and benign,
Our gloom-pleas'd eyes, embower'd from the light,
Enshaded in forgetfulness divine:
O soothest Sleep! if so it please thee, close
In midst of this thine hymn my willing eyes,
Or wait the "Amen," ere thy poppy throws
Around my bed its lulling charities.
Then save me, or the passed day will shine
Upon my pillow, breeding many woes,—
Save me from curious Conscience, that still lords
Its strength for darkness, burrowing like a mole;
Turn the key deftly in the oilèd wards,
And seal the hushèd Casket of my Soul.

54. The figure of speech associated with deep emotional expression and upon which Keats's "To Sleep" relies is

A) apostrophe.
B) euphemism.
C) hyperbole.
D) personification.
E) syllepsis.

55. The form of Keats's "To Sleep" is

A) dizain.
B) fourteener.
C) pantun.
D) sonnet.
E) *terza rima*.

56. Thematic to Keats's calling to sleep to save him from "curious Conscience" (line 11) is his

A) "burrowing like a mole."
B) cautious whisper to the Casket of his Soul.
C) desire to escape the troubles of waking life.
D) hymn.
E) understanding that sleep is not solitude.

57. The persona's attitude concerning sleep is

A) defiant.
B) fearful.
C) indignant.
D) inquisitive.
E) welcoming.

Items 58-61 refer to Mark Strand's

Two Horses

On a warm night in June
I went to the lake, got on all fours,
and drank like an animal. Two horses
came up beside me to drink as well.
This is amazing, I thought, but who will believe it?
The horses eyed me from time to time, snorting
and nodding. I felt the need to respond, so I snorted, too,
but haltingly, as though not really wanting to be heard.
The horses must have sensed that I was holding back.
They moved slightly away. Then I thought they might have known me
in another life—the one in which I was a poet.
They might have even read my poems, for back then,
in that shadowy time when our eagerness knew no bounds,
we changed styles almost as often as there were days in the year.

58. The persona's reflection on his former life suggests, perhaps, that poetry is

A) difficult, like the language of horses, to understand.
B) the language of the Houyhnhnms.
C) a recognizably natural, organic language.
D) a summer night-inspired activity.
E) understood better by animals.

59. The poem's operative simile occurs in

A) line 14.
B) line 11.
C) line 9.
D) line 6.
E) line 3.

60. The auditory imagery found in "snorting" (line 6) is an example of

A) amphigory.
B) cacophony.
C) consonance.
D) melopoeia.
E) onomatopoeia.

61. The form of Strand's poem is

A) beast fable.
B) blank verse.
C) fourteener.
D) free verse.
E) sonnet.

Items 62-65 refer to Edmund Waller's

To a Fair Lady, Playing with a Snake

Strange! that such horror and such grace
Should dwell together in one place;
A fury's arm, an angel's face!

'Tis innocence, and youth, which makes
In Chloris' fancy such mistakes,
To start at love, and play with snakes.

By this and by her coldness barred,
Her servants have a task too hard;
The tyrant has a double guard!

Thrice happy snake! that in her sleeve
May boldly creep; we dare not give
Our thoughts so unconfined a leave.

Contented in that nest of snow
He lies, as he his bliss did know,
And to the wood no more would go.

Take heed, fair Eve! you do not make
Another tempter of this snake;
A marble one so warmed would speak.

62. The form of Waller's poem is the

A) tercet.
B) *terza rima*.
C) triad.
D) tribrach.
E) triolet.

63. The poem's final stanza is a tribute to Eve's

A) boldness.
B) innocence.
C) loveliness.
D) playfulness.
E) youth.

64. The poem relies on the strength of its

A) archaism.
B) biblical allusion.
C) historical allusion.
D) nature allusion.
E) neoclassical allusions.

65. The strangeness to which the poem's persona refers in both the first and the second stanzas characterizes the

A) imagery of a snake's having an angel's face.
B) innocence and youth of Chloris.
C) paradox on which the observation depends.
D) persona's playing with snakes.
E) snake's ability to be both horrific and graceful.

The required Tie-Breaking Essay prompt is found on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.

Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three pages of blank paper have been provided for this essay; however, it is not expected that the essay will be longer than 150 words; however, the essay should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than a few sentences.

Read Theodore Roethke's "Root Cellar," and offer a discussion of the poet's sensitivity to nature as well as his awareness of the "agony of birth."

Root Cellar

Nothing would sleep in that cellar, dank as a ditch,
Bulbs broke out of boxes hunting for chinks in the dark,
Shoots dangled and drooped,
Lolling obscenely from mildewed crates,
Hung down long yellow evil necks, like tropical snakes.
And what a congress of stinks!—
Roots ripe as old bait,
Pulpy stems, rank, silo-rich,
Leaf-mold, manure, lime, piled against slippery planks.
Nothing would give up life:
Even the dirt kept breathing a small breath.

Theodore Roethke
1941

2nd _____ _____

1st _____ _____
score initials

University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest

ANSWER SHEET

Contestant # _____ Conference # _____

Please write answers as CAPITAL letters.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. _____	11. _____	21. _____
2. _____	12. _____	22. _____
3. _____	13. _____	23. _____
4. _____	14. _____	24. _____
5. _____	15. _____	25. _____
6. _____	16. _____	26. _____
7. _____	17. _____	27. _____
8. _____	18. _____	28. _____
9. _____	19. _____	29. _____
10. _____	20. _____	30. _____

number correct _____ x 1 pt each = _____

Part 2: UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

31. _____	38. _____	45. _____
32. _____	39. _____	46. _____
33. _____	40. _____	47. _____
34. _____	41. _____	48. _____
35. _____	42. _____	49. _____
36. _____	43. _____	50. _____
37. _____	44. _____	

number correct _____ x 2 pts each = _____

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism **15 items (2 points each)**

51. _____	56. _____	61. _____
52. _____	57. _____	62. _____
53. _____	58. _____	63. _____
54. _____	59. _____	64. _____
55. _____	60. _____	65. _____

number correct _____ x 2 pts each = _____

total points

University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest
Invitational A • 2011
KEY

Page numbers are those associated with the *Handbook* 11e, the Penguin 1996 edition of *P&P*, and the Vintage edition of *The Hairy Ape*.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History — **30 items (1 point each)**

1.	C	148	11.	E	562	21.	B	291/1
2.	D	382	12.	E	664	22.	E	416
3.	D	453	13.	D	329	23.	A	661
4.	A	104	14.	E	356	24.	C	231
5.	A	659	15.	B	611	25.	D	381
6.	C	662	16.	A	52	26.	B	242
7.	A	122	17.	B	269	27.	C	621
8.	E	542	18.	D	660	28.	B	340
9.	E	588	19.	C	377	29.	A	616
10.	D	443	20.	E	543	30.	C	198

Part 2: UIL Reading List — **20 items (2 points each)**

31.	A	143	38.	D	10	45.	D	
32.	A	156	39.	B		46.	B	
33.	C	175	40.	C	61	47.	B	107
34.	C	169	41.	A	151	48.	D	
35.	A		42.	E	298	49.	D	566
36.	E	139	43.	E	214	50.	B	226
37.	B		44.	D				

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism — **15 items (2 points each)**

51.	B		56.	C		61.	D	241
52.	B		57.	E		62.	A	547
53.	A		58.	C		63.	C	
54.	A	40	59.	E		64.	B	16
55.	D	519	60.	E	384	65.	C	

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Theodore Roethke's "Root Cellar"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of this poem include

alliteration,
assonance,
contrast,
diction,
imagery (sensual),
metaphor,
optimism,
personification,
sigmatism,
simile sympathy/empathy,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant is asked to consider the persona's sensitivity to nature and his awareness of the "agony of birth" as they give meaning to Roethke's "Root Cellar." The careful observer will note the optimism in the opening declaration, "Nothing would sleep" (living must be active); he or she might also note the profundity of the last two lines in which the optimism, relative to the imagery that pervades the description of the cellar, exudes from the darkness and the dankness: "Nothing would give up life: / Even the dirt kept breathing [. . .]."

The imagery is visual and olfactory; additionally, the word choices whisper primal activity. The young writer might notice Roethke's use of sound devices to accentuate the activity, which, while certainly visual, must be imagined (as well as heard and smelled) because the cellar is dark.

The writer who has been working with Roethke's poetry might focus on the bracketing "Nothing woulds," found in line 1 and lines 10-11, and address the poet's sensitivity to nature, which is framed by implicit personification through sympathetic comparison (sleeping and breathing): there is something in all that lives, especially in its coming to life, that is immediately observable in nature. The natural world has a soul that resonates in our observing it in its "small breaths."